

Book of Abstracts

VIOLENCE AND EMPIRE FROM THE EARLY 1800S TO THE END OF THE GREAT WAR

6 and 7 March 2026 – Naples

Keynote Speakers

Tanja Bühner

Violence and Empire during the Long Nineteenth Century

Georgina Sinclair

*Revisiting the impact of 'colonial' and 'authoritarian' policing models
in an era of global disruption, 1945 – 2025*

Organising and Scientific Committee

Luca Bertolani Azeredo

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Institutional Greetings

Daniela Luigia Caglioti

Neus Anglès i Borràs is a PhD candidate in History at the Rovira i Virgili University and a researcher in the ISOCAC group (History, Society, Politics, and Culture from Catalonia to the World). Her research examines the relationship between the anarchist movement and Afro-Cuban religious practices in fin-de-siècle Cuba (c. 1880–1905), exploring both ideological discourses and everyday practices of coexistence, as well as shared state repression. To this end, she employs a methodology that combines historical-conceptual analysis of the libertarian press with microhistory, consulting judicial, governmental, and associational archival collections. Her work is funded by the FI-SDUR “Joan Oró” predoctoral grant from the Generalitat de Catalunya–Next Generation EU.

Sacredness and power: Afro-Cuban religions in contexts of intra-imperial violence

The aim of this paper is to examine how Afro-Cuban religions—Abakúa, Santería, and Palo Monte—were interpreted and treated by both the Spanish colonial power and the anarchist movement in Cuba between the late 19th and early 20th centuries. It is proposed that these religions constitute a privileged prism for analysing the tensions between imperial violence, anti-clericalism and cultural resistance in a context marked by coloniality and the struggle for emancipation.

Firstly, the relationship between the colonial authorities and Afro-Cuban religions is addressed. Although they were often persecuted and criminalised on charges of superstition or barbarism, which legitimised police repression, legal penalisation and cultural censorship, this attitude was not uniform. In certain contexts, the colonial power also tolerated or even promoted these practices as a way of channelling the cultural life of Afro-descendants and, at the same time, containing political expressions of resistance. In this way, imperial violence was expressed both in open repression and in cultural instrumentalization, subordinating Afro-descendant religious practices to a framework of racial and symbolic domination.

Secondly, the position of anarchism is examined. The movement, marked by strong anti-clericalism, directed its criticism mainly against Catholicism as a supporter of the colonial and republican order. However, when it came to religions of African descent, anarchist discourse and practices oscillated between disqualification—based on a universalist rationalism of Western origin—and recognition of these religions as forms of cultural and community resistance to colonial hegemony. In short, this paper seeks to show how Afro-Cuban religions were situated at the intersection of imperial violence, cultural control and emancipatory struggles, and how the anarchist view of them allows us to reflect on the limits, tensions and contradictions of modernity's emancipatory projects.

Carla-Maëlys Barboutie (Universities of Grenoble Alpes)

Carla-Maëlys Barboutie is a PhD-Student at the University Grenoble Alpes and the University of Innsbruck since October 2022. Since August 2025, she joined the German Historical Institute in Paris. Her research project has the working title *Perspectives nouvelles sur la Légion étrangère française en contexte colonial et impérial (1831-1914)*. She previously completed a tri-national dual bachelor's degree in French modern literature and history between the universities of Mainz, Dijon, and Sherbrooke, followed by a Franco-Italian master's degree in history at the universities of Grenoble and Siena. As part of this master's program, she studied the reception of the Boxer War (1900–1901), first in France and Germany, and then from a comparative perspective also including Italy. Since then, she has focused on the history of colonialism, migration, and war.

Colonial Violence from Within: Disciplinary practices in the French Foreign Legion in 19th Century Africa

*In 2023, French filmmaker Guy Beauché released the documentary *The Tears of the Legion*, which examines the torture and violence endured by soldiers of the French Foreign Legion within the unit known as the *Section d'Épreuve de la Légion Étrangère (SELE)* in Corsica during the second half of the twentieth century. The film breaks a longstanding silence, shedding light on abusive practices within the French army itself.*

*Yet, violence in the Foreign Legion was not confined to the twentieth century. It can be traced back to the Legion creation in 1831 as part of the *Armée d'Afrique*. Indeed, while the French government publicly condemned and sought to prohibit “unjustified” violence in the metropolitan army during the nineteenth century, colonial contexts—especially in Africa—permitted a wide range of abuses, inflicted not only on local populations but also on soldiers of the *Armée d'Afrique*. These abuses included malnutrition, physical punishment, and various corporal sanctions. Legionnaires were subjected to non-regulatory punishments such as beatings, as well as institutionalized forms of abuse, including the infamous “Silo,” where soldiers were forced to stand upright in a dug-out hole. Despite recurrent scandals in France, such practices persisted well into the twentieth century and were routinely justified by officers and war ministers as necessary tools for controlling men depicted as unruly and threatening to the colonial order.*

*This paper examines these different forms of violence within the French Foreign Legion and argues that they reveal a dual ambiguity. First, violence served as a means of controlling the troops and maintaining the colonial order; yet it also provoked forms of resistance. Legionnaires responded through acts of rebellion, including desertion or the display of provocative tattoos. Second, the paper highlights the French government's double standard: tolerating practices in Africa that would have been unacceptable in metropolitan France. Finally, this study builds on Dominique Kalifa's work on *Biribi* (the system of colonial penal camps) and seeks to make visible the practices of violence, their representations, and the responses they elicited within the Legion, so that it may no longer remain a “non-lieu de mémoire,” in Kalifa's sense of the term and instead become a “lieu histoire”.*

Franco Barchiesi (Ohio State University)

Franco Barchiesi is associate professor in Comparative Studies and African American and African Studies at the Ohio State University. He also held teaching positions at the University of the Witwatersrand, Johannesburg—where he received his PhD in Sociology—the University of Bologna, and Brooklyn College, as well as an Andrews Fellowship at the Hutchins Center for African and African American Research, Harvard University. A former senior editor of the journal *International Labor and Working-Class History*, Franco was awarded the 2012 CLR James Book Award from the Working-Class Studies Association for his *Precarious Liberation: Workers, the State, and Contested Social Citizenship in Postapartheid South Africa* (State University of New York Press). Franco's current research is on the antiblackness of labor regimes across the Atlantic between the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries in relation to the emergence of modern liberalism as a modality of rule.

“The Point of View of the Dominant Race”:

Violence, the Employment Contract, and Liberal Spectralities of Slavery in South Africa from the “Langeberg Rebellion” (1896-97) to the “Chinese Labor Question” (1904-07)

At the turn from the nineteenth to the twentieth century, the emergence of an imperial liberal anglosphere found in South Africa a terrain of experimentation. A strong white settler tradition of political liberalism in the Cape Colony envisaged a potential non-coercive reconciliation between wage labor as a universal political economy principle and the racial subjugation of African societies. My paper discusses two historically distinct moments in this trajectory on account of their imaginative and ideological affinities. In 1897, Cape colonial forces violently suppressed the wave of BaThlaping and BaThlalo resistance known as the “Langeberg Rebellion” (“Ntwa ya Bana ba Mokgothu” in SeTswana). Hundreds of unarmed prisoners were summarily identified as “rebels” and offered a choice between military trials or contracts of indenture for them and their families (including children). Outrage at the scheme from humanitarian quarters pointed at its similarities with slavery. But the prevailing liberal opinion, exemplified by influential jurist, James Rose Innes, was that while enforcing waged work in lieu of criminal prosecution departed from the rule of law and contractual freedom as British liberal values, the “point of view” of whiteness as the “dominant race” dictated that it was in the objective interest of all “natives” to be brought under such norms by whatever means in alternative to destitution and starvation. White liberals, in South Africa and the empire at large, were far more determined to turn the specter of “slavery” into a principled issue seven years later, when indentured labor from southern China was recruited for the Transvaal mines, which Black workers deserted in the aftermath of the 1899-1902 South African War. Opposition to “Chinese labor” was indeed a factor in the rise of Britain’s Liberal Party to power in 1906. The paper’s core argument is threefold. First, the postabolition liberal rhetorical arsenal used slavery to legitimize the racial violence of wage labor by separating it from deliberate coercion. Second, the ideological coherence of this operation was secured by making continuing Black captivity illegible in terms akin to slavery. Third, antiblack erasure allowed the use of “slavery” to signal infringements of the “free labor” rights of white British subjects and non-Black workers alike.

Jamal Ali Bashir (Martin Luther University Halle-Wittenberg)

Jama Ali Bashir is a political scientist specializing in colonial and post-colonial governance in Pakistan, with a focus on land, infrastructure, and state-building. His current book project, provisionally titled *Patronage as Infrastructure: Land, Water, and Politics in Naseerabad, Balochistan*, examines how the state has governed this agrarian frontier from the late 19th century through the Bhutto era. Drawing on archival research and fieldwork, the project demonstrates how land tenure, irrigation networks, and public employment have functioned as instruments of patronage and control.

He holds a PhD in Political Science from Martin-Luther University Halle-Wittenberg, where his research explored the evolution of patronage and elite–state relations in Pakistan’s peripheries. His broader research interests include political ecology, agrarian change, and the enduring impact of colonial institutions in South Asia. He is particularly interested in the governance of marginal regions through a combination of legal authority, development initiatives, and routinized forms of coercion.

Security, Patronage, and Everyday Violence in Colonial Naseerabad

This paper examines how the British colonial state governed Naseerabad, a frontier zone in eastern Balochistan, through a combination of patronage, indirect rule, and coercion. It asks two related questions: what forms of everyday violence shaped the incorporation of this frontier zone into the colonial state, and how did the state balance its goals of security, authority, and revenue generation when those goals came into tension?

The argument is straightforward. First, Naseerabad was never primarily a revenue-generating area. It was governed as a strategic buffer, and its political arrangements were shaped accordingly. Second, violence on the frontier was not exceptional or ad hoc. It was legal, infrastructural, and routinized. It was embedded in mechanisms like levy thana, land settlement, and co-opted jirgas. The approach of the paper is qualitative and archival. The paper is based on land settlement reports, internal correspondence, and colonial policy documents to reconstruct how British administrators framed and managed the region. It does not focus on spectacular acts of force but on how coercion was institutionalized in law, administration, and property.

The paper proceeds in four sections. It begins by situating Naseerabad within broader colonial frontier policy in 19th century. It then traces how land settlement was used to resettle and reward tribes on the frontier. Third, it looks at policing through local intermediaries and the normalization of coercion. Finally, it reflects on what this case shows about violence, not as a breakdown of governance, but as a technique of rule.

The contribution is to bring the history of a rarely studied area into broader debates on empire and violence and to show how coercive stability was achieved not despite the state’s legal and institutional frameworks, but through them.

Kato Desaeveer (KU Leuven)

Kato Desaeveer is a PhD candidate in Legal History at KU Leuven Kulak, where she also works as a teaching assistant. Under the supervision of Prof. Dr. Inge Van Hulle and Prof. Dr. Vincent Sagaert, her research compares the legal and economic dimensions of concession contracts between colonial Congo and Belgium (1876 and 1967). Drawing on interdisciplinary methods and comparative legal analysis, her work examines how legal frameworks both influenced and reflected colonial economic structures and imperial governance. She focuses in particular on the property law implications of these agreements. She began her doctoral studies in October 2024 after completing her Master of Laws at KU Leuven earlier that year.

Violence for Profit: The Legal Architecture of Violence Imbedded in the Land Regime of Congo Free State (1885–1908)

This paper is situated within the field of legal and colonial history, engaging with current debates on the legal infrastructures of colonial violence and the political economy of empire. It examines how the Congo Free State (1885–1908) institutionalised violence as a way of profitmaking and territorial control through the twin mechanisms of the concessionary system and the legal fiction of terres vacantes (“vacant lands”). Rather than viewing violence as the breakdown of law, the paper argues that it was embedded within legal and administrative rationalities that enabled extraction and domination.

The Congo Free State, unique as the personal possession of King Leopold II (1835–1909) rather than a metropolitan colony, developed a regime in which sovereignty and commerce were indistinguishable. Vast territories were declared vacant and transferred to concessionary companies, which were granted quasi-sovereign rights to exploit natural resources. Within this framework, violence became both the means and the measure of profitability. Forced labour, hostage-taking, punitive expeditions, and mutilations were not merely tolerated excesses but integral components of a system that linked coercion to economic performance. The legal fiction of terres vacantes thus operated as an instrument of expropriation, while concessionary charters transformed private enterprise into an extension of violent state power.

Methodologically, the paper draws on legal-historical and archival analysis, examining concession contracts, administrative decrees, and the records of the 1904 Commission of Inquiry alongside contemporary legal commentaries. Through these sources, it traces how legal concepts and bureaucratic forms legitimised violence as a tool of governance and profit. The findings presented form part of my doctoral research, which investigates the property law implications of concession contracts in colonial Congo, and employs an instrumental comparative approach with Belgian concession contracts of the same period.

Martin Klečacký (Czech Academy of Sciences)

Martin Klečacký is a Czech historian and research fellow at the Masaryk Institute and Archives of the Czech Academy of Sciences in Prague. His work focuses on modern political and social history of Bohemian Lands and the Habsburg Monarchy, with particular attention to public administration, political elites, parliamentarianism, and how state power was exercised at the local level. Grounded in extensive archival research, his scholarship links institutional change to the everyday practices of governance and the political pressures of the late imperial and interwar eras.

His major publications include the monograph *Poslušný vládce okresu: Okresní hejtman a proměny státní moci v Čechách v letech 1868–1938* (Obedient Master of the District. District Captain and Changes in State Power in Bohemia in the Years 1868–1938; 2021) and the forthcoming book *The Politics of Appointment: The Czech Minister and the Transformation of Habsburg Administration* (Berghahn, 2026). Currently, he is a member of the Czech Science Foundation project *Protest Culture in the Bohemian Lands between 1890 and 1938*.

The Violence in the Name of Law: A Statistical Anatomy of Coercion in the Late Habsburg Empire

"In the context of the Habsburg Monarchy, the gendarme was a key instrument of imperial dominance and the projection of state authority. Unlike municipal police forces, the gendarmerie was a centrally organized and managed corps, directly subordinate to state authorities and responsible for security across the entire territory. Its massive numerical growth from its establishment in 1849 to the empire's collapse underscores its fundamental role in enforcing state authority, especially in rural and peripheral regions of the monarchy.

While imperial violence is often studied through major conflicts or legal texts, its everyday, "low-level" application by state forces remains a methodologically challenging field. This paper addresses this gap by presenting a unique quantitative analysis based on archival material: comprehensive statistical reports on the use of weapons by the gendarmerie across all Crown Lands of the Habsburg Monarchy between 1876 and 1903. These annual reports meticulously document each instance of weapon use, its outcome (light injury, severe injury, or death), and situate these data within the context of regional population figures and the number of gendarmes deployed in the province.

This dataset provides an unprecedented window into the bureaucratization of force and coercion. By employing a comparative approach, the paper examines how the frequency and lethality of state violence varied across the empire's diverse ethnic, cultural, religious, and socio-economic landscapes. By comparing rates of violence, this study challenges monolithic views of Habsburg imperial rule, revealing a differentiated landscape of coercion. It argues that these statistics were not merely passive records but active instruments of imperial control, shaping perceptions of order and operationalizing violence as a calculated, documented, and constitutive force in the maintenance of the empire. This approach directly engages with the institutionalization of violence through policing and the legal and bureaucratic frameworks used to regulate and rationalize it."

Ilaria Masseroni (KU Leuven)

Ilaria Masseroni is, as of November 2023, a PhD Candidate in Colonial Legal History at the Department of Roman Law and Legal History of KU Leuven's Faculty of Law. More specifically, she is developing a project called "Polygamy in the Congo Free State and Belgian Congo: A Comparative Study between Law and Literature" under the supervision of Prof. Dr. Inge Van Hulle. She graduated in Law at the University of Trento (March 2021). In 2017, she won a merit-based scholarship to complete a double degree program of one year at Washington University in St. Louis, MO, USA. Thus, in May 2018, she obtained an LLM in Intellectual Property and Technology Law. As she strongly believes in the value of interdisciplinarity and on the importance of the dialogue between different subjects, she has also successfully completed a Master in English and French Literary Studies and Linguistics at Vrije Universiteit Brussel (August 2023).

Symbolic and Socio-Legal Violence in the Congo Free State: Polygamy as a Site of Imperial Control

This paper analyzes how the discourse and regulation of polygamy functioned as a form of symbolic and legal violence within the Congo Free State (1885–1908), situating this practice at the core of Leopold II's "civilizing mission" and the emerging logics of imperial control. European narratives, from travel literature to fictional works by authors like Henry Morton Stanley, Joseph Conrad, and Arthur Conan Doyle, routinely pathologized polygamy as a sign of African moral disorder and racial "backwardness," thereby justifying colonial intervention. This construction of the African polygamist as the antithesis of the European moral order served as an ideological apparatus to legitimize conquest, to explore the cultural justification of imperial violence. Despite the rhetorical focus, the Congo Free State's formal legislative framework provided a legal void on polygamy for the indigenous population; the state prioritized regulating non-indigenous family life and promoting monogamy only among the military and the small, educated évolués elite. This absence of consistent legal enforcement was filled by Belgian Catholic missionaries, who were instrumentalized by the state as quasi-legal actors. Through the creation of Catholic villages and the practice of financially facilitating (or even performing the equivalent of purchasing) Christian marriages to impose monogamy, missionaries actively enforced colonial norms and transformed indigenous social structures. The paper argues that this strategic outsourcing of moral governance to the Church, formalized by the 1906 Concordat and financial subsidies, reveals how violence in the Free State was not only physical (as famously exposed by reformers) but also institutional and ideological. By blurring the lines between religious authority and state function, this system utilized the regulation of intimate life as a crucial tool for political and social control, anticipating the more systematic assimilationist campaigns of the Belgian Congo period.

Joshua Meeks (US Naval War College)

Dr. Joshua Meeks is a professor of strategy and policy at the US Naval War College. His research examines how small states navigate great power competition, with a particular focus on the political and strategic transformations of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. His work has explored these dynamics in the Western Mediterranean during the War of the First Coalition, especially through the case of Corsica and its shifting relationship to French power. He is currently expanding this research to include neutrality in the Baltic and a global history project on the Napoleonic moment that extends the analysis both geographically and temporally beyond Napoleon himself. In his current position, he teaches strategic analysis to military officers, drawing primarily on military history.

Empire at Home: Violence, Administration, and the Making of French Rule in Corsica, 1790–1815

In the decades surrounding the French Revolution and the Napoleonic wars, Corsica occupied a peculiar position: formally a department of the Republic and Empire, yet governed through methods that diverged sharply from those applied on the mainland. This paper examines how French officials approached Corsica as an internal frontier where political authority had to be asserted, defended, and continually re-articulated.

Using administrative correspondence, military memoranda, and judicial dossiers, the study traces how local conflict, including clan rivalries, anti-French agitation, and shifting allegiances, was interpreted through a vocabulary of disorder that justified unusually intrusive and violent state practices. Prefects and generals treated the island as a terrain requiring concentrated surveillance and the steady presence of armed force, while special jurisdictions, roving gendarmerie detachments, and provisional regulations blurred any clear line between civil administration and military command.

*The paper argues that violence in Corsica was not simply reactive but played a formative role in shaping the island's incorporation into the French polity. The techniques adopted there, including tightened policing, collective responsibility measures, and the identification of communities considered inherently unstable, anticipated approaches later used in France's overseas possessions. At the same time, metropolitan observers constructed Corsica as a place governed by passion and vendetta. Alexandre Dumas' *The Corsican Brothers*, written several decades later, crystallized these tropes and revealed how nineteenth-century France continued to imagine the island as both part of the nation and culturally foreign.*

By situating Corsica within broader discussions of state formation and imperial governance, this paper shows how the island served as an early testing ground for forms of authority that operated at the intersection of law, force, and representation.

Emilia Musumeci (University of Teramo)

Emilia Musumeci is Associate Professor of History of Medieval and Modern Law at the University of Teramo, where she teaches Introduction to Legal History, History of Criminal Law and Criminology, History of Environmental Law, and Law & Gender at the Department of Law. She holds the Italian National Scientific Qualification (Abilitazione Scientifica Nazionale) as Full Professor in the same field. Her research interests include Cesare Lombroso's criminal anthropology and its legacy in contemporary neuroscience, the role of emotions in criminal law and criminal justice, the historical intersections between medicine and law, the legal history of the body, and the broader interdisciplinary field of Law and the Humanities. A member of various international academic associations, she has delivered lectures and seminars at leading universities and research centres across Europe. She has published extensively in Italian and international journals and edited volumes and is the author of three monographs: *Cesare Lombroso e le neuroscienze: un parricidio mancato* (FrancoAngeli, Milan, 2012); *Emozioni, Crimine, Giustizia. Un'indagine storico-giuridica tra Otto e Novecento* (FrancoAngeli, Milan, 2015); *Veneficium. Storia di un crimine atroce* (Eum, Macerata, 2022).

Spectacle and Discipline: Corporal Punishment in Italian Colonial Eritrea (1890–1918)

This paper explores the use of violence in the administration of punishment in Italian Eritrea from its formal annexation in 1890 to the end of the Great War, with a focus on the codification and public staging of corporal penalties. While the 1889 Zanardelli Code marked a liberal turn in metropolitan Italy, abolishing the death penalty and curtailing cruel punishments, colonial Eritrea operated under a regime of permanent exception. Here, Italian criminal law coexisted uneasily with indigenous customary norms and racialised theories that framed Eritreans as “savages” to be disciplined.

Drawing on judicial archives, administrative ordinances, and legal treatises, the paper examines how colonial magistrates, influenced by Criminal Anthropology and the Positivist School of Criminal Law, constructed the colonised as “eternal minors.” This infantilisation, allegedly a physiological rather than pathological state, justified their diminished criminal responsibility and the retention of sanctions deemed “appropriate” to their stage of civilisation. In practice, corporal punishments such as flogging, the bastinado, and public beatings were not vestiges of premodern justice but central instruments of colonial governance. Administered in market squares, military posts, and village centres, they functioned as spectacles of domination, ritualised displays in which the colonial state inscribed its authority on the bodies of its subjects. These acts of violence were carefully choreographed: the choice of location, the presence of military personnel, and the summoning of onlookers transformed punishment into a didactic performance aimed at deterrence and submission. By situating Eritrean penal practices within broader imperial patterns, the paper highlights how physical coercion operated alongside legal rationalisation to sustain colonial order. It argues that the racialised construction of diminished responsibility not only enabled the retention of corporal punishment but also reinforced hierarchies of civilisation that persisted in postcolonial legal and political cultures.

Florian Neiske (University of Marburg)

Florian Neiske is a PhD candidate at the University of Marburg, Germany. His research examines the nexus between different natural phenomena like cyclonic storms, droughts, and diseases and the structures, mechanisms and imaginations of British colonial rule in Bengal in the latter half of the 19th Century with a special focus on notions of insecurity and disaster. Currently, he works as an assistant for event organization and management at the Herder Institute for Historical Research on East Central Europe. He previously worked as a research assistant in the SFB/TRR 138 “Dynamics of Security”, sub-project C08 “Security and Empire”, at the University of Marburg. Florian Neiske holds a bachelor’s degree in geography and history from the University of Münster and a master’s degree in History of international Politics from the University of Marburg. He teaches courses on imperial and environmental history and established a (post)colonial city walk in Marburg.

Violent Storms.

Disaster Politics and Ecological Violence in Colonial Bengal, 1864-1899

Research on violence in British-India has shown the intrinsic and intimate connection between violence and colonial rule. Studies in this context have so far focused mainly on different forms of interpersonal violence including murder, (sexual) assault, battery, but also torture, corporal punishment, forced labour and migration. This proposed paper argues that forms of ecological violence should be included in our discussions on the violence of colonialism. Drawing on concepts from political ecology, environmental sociology and history ecological violence is understood as a ‘more-than-human’ history. But rather than looking for simple environmental triggers of violence, the concept asks how violence was enacted in, with and through ecological processes. It therefore combines an analysis of political economy, social relations and cultural meaning with the workings of environmental phenomena.

To explore the notion of ecological violence, I focus on a series of cyclonic storms that hit British ruled Bengal in the latter half of the Nineteenth-Century. As storms can be classified as multi-hazard phenomena, they carry potential for inflicting various forms of physical and emotional harm. Wind speeds over 200 kilometers per hour tore up home and trees, leaving fields of debris. Storm surges swept over landscapes, drowning humans and animals alike, while torrents of rain were registered far from the coastlines. Initial survivors often remained in a weakened position with no access to clean water and epidemics following close by. The proposed paper analyses how colonial policies and administrative structures contributed to an increased vulnerability that carried through the colonial management of several disasters. Furthermore, the conceptualization of disaster itself led to the continuation and administrative legitimization of suffering and harm. As a way of constituting relations with nature, disaster politics in colonial settings also point our attention to questions about who could be seen as legitimate political subject.

Lukas Rijntalder (University of Potsdam and University College, Dublin)

Lukas Rijntalder is a Defence Analyst at the Center for the Study of Democracy, where his work focuses on cognitive warfare, defence innovation, civil-military relations, and hybrid threats, with particular attention to Eastern Europe and the European security environment. He holds a Dual MA in War Studies, completed at the University of Potsdam and University College Dublin, and a BA in History and International Studies from the Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam. During his studies, Lukas completed an internship at the Konrad Adenauer Stiftung Political Dialogue Asia Programme, where he worked on EU-ASEAN relations, Southeast Asian politics, and regional security. He also previously interned at the Center for the Study of Democracy, contributing to research on governance, societal resilience, and hybrid threats in Eastern Europe. Alongside his professional work, Lukas pursues historical analysis, with research interests focused on diplomacy, conflict, and international relations, particularly in the European and wider Eurasian context.

**Law, Punishment, and the Civilising Mission:
Institutionalised Violence in the Dutch East Indies, 1830–1904**

This paper examines how the Dutch colonial state in the East Indies institutionalised violence through legal and administrative mechanisms, making coercion a routine instrument of governance. Drawing on historical and legal studies, as well as insights from colonial and imperial history, it analyses how law, bureaucracy, and local intermediaries enabled the Dutch to impose control over indigenous populations during the 19th century, with particular attention to the Cultivation System (1830s–1870s) and the Aceh War (1873–1904).

The research asks: to what extent did Dutch legal and administrative frameworks rationalise and normalise violence as part of the colonial ‘civilising mission’? It argues that violence in the Dutch East Indies was neither incidental nor episodic but embedded in the structural logic of colonial governance. Legal codes, bureaucratic oversight, and local regents codified coercive practices such as forced labour, corporal punishment, and public executions. These mechanisms legitimised coercion as lawful and necessary for economic extraction and political order, while narratives of civilisation and moral duty masked the human cost.

The study relies on colonial legal codes, administrative correspondence between Batavia and local regents, and official reports on military campaigns, linking normative frameworks with observed practices to demonstrate how violence was operationalised and culturally narrated.

By situating coercion at the centre of imperial governance, the paper highlights the intertwined roles of law, bureaucracy, and military force in sustaining Dutch colonial rule. It contributes to broader debates on the moral and structural foundations of empire in the long nineteenth century, illustrating how violence was institutionalised, justified, and perceived within the framework of legality and civilisation. The research offers comparative insights for scholars of other European empires and deepens our understanding of the enduring legacies of colonial coercion.

Kamil Ruszala (Jagiellonian University of Kraków)

Dr Kamil Ruszala is an Assistant Professor of Modern History at the Jagiellonian University in Kraków, Poland. He studied in Kraków (Jagiellonian University), Vienna (University of Vienna), and Prague (Charles University). His research focuses on the history of East-Central Europe, the Habsburg Monarchy, the First World War, the anthropology of war, WW1 refugees and refugee camps, war violence, post-imperial transformations, and the sites of memory and trauma of the WW1/post WW1. He is the author of several monographs, edited volumes, and numerous scholarly articles in these fields. He serves as Principal Investigator of several research projects devoted to refugee history, WW1 and biopolitics, the commemoration and heritage of the First World War. He is a member of several international research networks on migration, displacement, and war experiences, and acts as Managing Editor of 1914–1918-Online. International Encyclopedia of the First World War. He has held visiting research and teaching positions in Paris (2019), Chicago (2020), Buffalo (2021), Antwerp (2021), Rome (2022), the Institute for Human Sciences (IWM) in Vienna (2022/2023), Copenhagen (2023) or Constance (2026).

Pandora's Box of Imperial Violence:

Wartime State of Exception, Violence of Isolation in Late Habsburg Empire

*This paper examines the longue durée of imperial violence within the Habsburg Empire from the mid-19th century to the First World War, focusing on how coercive practices were embedded in state structures and territorial governance in East-Central Europe. In Austria-Hungary, where legal rights and civic privileges were generally broader than in neighbouring empires (the Romanov Empire), imperial stability depended on subtle but pervasive mechanisms of disciplining a highly diverse population. Throughout the nineteenth century, imperial authorities expanded policing and bureaucratic apparatuses, relying on surveillance, legal instruments, and selective repression to manage ethnic minorities and politically suspect groups, especially in peripheral regions such as Galicia and Bukovina. These developments reveal how violence was institutionalised within imperial modernity – not only through explicit force but also through administrative routines, legal exceptions, and policing. Violence, however, was not purely top-down. Everyday unrest, mass protests, and street violence in Vienna exposed powerful popular currents that shaped coercive state practices (Boyer & Francis, *Unruly Masses*, 1995). Violence thus circulated between population and power, not merely emanating from the imperial centre. The outbreak of the First World War marked a turning point, a “Pandora’s box” moment, when latent coercive practices escalated dramatically under the state of exception. In borderland regions, civilian administrations were replaced by military governors; entire populations came under intensified surveillance and control. Ethnic groups perceived as unreliable, particularly Ruthenians/Ukrainians and Poles holding Russian citizenship, became targets of internment and deportation. Refugee and internment camps emerged as “internal colonies,” spaces of surveillance and experimentation that resonate with Giorgio Agamben’s conceptualisation of camps as paradigmatic spaces of modern politics, where normal legal order is suspended and where individuals are reduced to “bare life,” subjected to surveillance, confinement, and coercion. While wartime violence is often analysed through the lens of military frontlines, this paper focuses on the home front as a space of imperial violence, shaped by the reciprocal dynamics between state discipline and societal unrest. It argues that these interactions transformed imperial peripheries into laboratories of modern coercive governance, revealing how imperial violence operated as both a top-down and bottom-up force during the era of total war.*